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After the Story: The One Question the Lights Would Not Answer

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A companion study to *The Hills Above Allentown*

Back Up the Mountain

Let's pull a chair in closer and go back up South Mountain one more time.

The pull-off sat right at the edge, with a steel guardrail so cold Dani could feel it through her coat sleeve. Down the slope the sumac had turned red as a stop sign, and past it the whole city of Allentown was coming on one streetlight at a time.

Then the lights came up out of the red bushes, and the map lady started talking out of Isaiah's phone.

Isaiah Whitfield did what a smart kid ought to do with a voice like that, and he tested it. He asked how many cars were on the freight train, and when the voice said ninety-one, Bryce braced his shaking elbows on the rail and counted every car until he got ninety-one. Isaiah asked for his grandmother's middle name, and the voice said Loretta. Every question he had, they passed, and they still wanted him over that rail.

Then a twelve-year-old girl in flat black school shoes pulled a small blue Bible out of her backpack and held it against her coat. She asked the one question her mother had given her years earlier in Santiago while sitting on the edge of the bed with the fan running. "¿Jesucristo vino en carne? Sí o no." Jesus Christ came in the body. Yes or no?

The lights that knew the train and knew Loretta wouldn't say a word to that one question. Even Isaiah, with one leg over the guardrail and Bryce hanging off the back of his belt, told them, "It's a yes or a no."

That silence is what we're going to talk about tonight.

Questions to Sit With

1. The lights got every one of Isaiah's questions right, and they were still trying to get him over the guardrail. Read Deuteronomy 13:1-3 and 2 Corinthians 11:14. Why can a voice be right about a lot of facts and still be lying about the one that matters most?
2. Read 1 John 4:1-3. Out of every question in the world, why did John give the church that one, about Jesus Christ coming in the flesh, as the test?
3. Read Acts 19:13-16, then think about Yadiel stepping up to the rail in his brother's William Allen hoodie. He spoke the Name the way his abuela said it the day the grease caught fire. Why did the name of Jesus work for Yadiel on that mountain, when it went so badly for the sons of Sceva?

The Teaching: Test the Spirits

The apostle John was an old man when he wrote the letter we call 1 John. The churches he loved had teachers coming through who claimed the Spirit had told them new things, and many Bible teachers think some of them said the Son of God never really had a body. John's answer is plain: don't believe every spirit, test them. Any spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God, and any spirit that won't confess Jesus isn't from God (1 John 4:1-3). In the first lines of that same letter he talks about the One he heard, saw with his own eyes, and touched with his own hands (1 John 1:1).

Isaiah's instinct to test was a good one, and God isn't afraid of being checked. Norman Geisler and Frank Turek point out that the Bible itself tells believers to question religious claims, listing 1 John 4:1 and Deuteronomy 13 among the places it does (Geisler and Turek, ch. 1, p. 47). His tests were good as far as they went, since ninety-one was a real number and Bryce counted it car by car. The gap was that every test Isaiah picked was one the lights could pass. In Deuteronomy 13, Moses warned Israel about a prophet whose sign comes true and who then says, let's go follow other gods, telling the people not to listen to him. Paul says that Satan dresses himself up as an angel of light (2 Corinthians 11:14), and a light that can count train cars is still only a light.

John Lennox is a mathematician at Oxford who has spent years answering people who think science can explain everything. He calls that belief scientism, and he says plainly that "Reason has a far larger scope than science" (Lennox, ch. 2). His picture is his Aunt Matilda's cake. The

world's best scientists can test every protein and particle in it, and still none of them can say why she baked it unless she tells them herself. Isaiah's phone and his questions could measure the lights, but they could never tell him whose side the lights were on. Lennox says we only get to know a person when that person reveals himself, usually by speaking, and the Bible's big claim is that God has spoken in His Son (Lennox, ch. 9). Did that Son come in the flesh? That was the question Isaiah never got around to asking until Dani asked it.

We should be careful here, because the story never says the lights couldn't say the name of Jesus, and the Bible never says evil spirits can't. In Mark 5:7 the spirits in the man from the tombs call Jesus the Son of the Most High God, and James 2:19 says the demons believe in one God and shudder. John's test asks for a confession. Will this voice agree, out loud and on God's side, that Jesus Christ came in the flesh? The lights could have said the word Jesus any time they wanted, yet they wouldn't give Dani her yes.

Think about why that question stopped them cold. "We made the first of you," the map lady said. "We were here before your city." That's the old ancient-astronaut story in new clothes, which is the idea that beings from out in space made us or planted life here. Geisler and Turek note that even a few well-known scientists have floated the idea that aliens planted the first life on earth, and then they ask the obvious next question: "who made the intelligent aliens?" (Geisler and Turek, ch. 5, p. 121). The claim only pushes the mystery back a step.

The Bible gives a straight answer, saying God made the first of us (Genesis 1:27), and from one man He made every nation on the earth (Acts 17:26). Then the Maker did the thing no fake maker would ever own up to. He came down into His own world, took on a body, and died on a cross. On the third day He walked out of the tomb in that same body and told His friends to touch Him and see (John 1:14; Luke 24:39). A voice that claims to be our maker can't say yes to Dani's question without admitting there's a real Maker, that He came in the flesh, and that the voice isn't Him. So it says nothing at all.

That's why the resurrection matters so much. Paul writes that Christ died for our sins, was buried, and was raised on the third day, and then he names who saw Him: Peter, the Twelve, more than five hundred people at once with most of them still alive to ask, then James, then Paul himself (1 Corinthians 15:3-8). If Christ wasn't raised, Paul says, our faith is useless (15:17). Working through that passage, Josh and Sean McDowell say the faith rises or falls with the resurrection

(McDowell and McDowell, *Bible Handbook*, "Difficult Verses from the Books of 1 & 2 Corinthians"). In *More Than a Carpenter* they put it this way: "The Resurrection takes the question 'Is Christianity valid?' out of the realm of philosophy and makes it a question of history" (ch. 10). History is something anyone can check.

The Name works the same honest way. In Acts 19, seven sons of a man named Sceva tried to drive out an evil spirit by saying, in the name of the Jesus that Paul preaches, borrowing a name that didn't belong to them. The spirit answered that it knew Jesus and knew Paul, but who were they? Then the man jumped on them and beat them until they ran out of the house hurt and stripped (Acts 19:13-16). The Name carries power for people who belong to Jesus when they call on the One it belongs to. Yadiel learned it in a kitchen where his abuela prayed out loud every morning over the radio, and when he said it loud and flat and sure, the lights stopped like they had run into the guardrail.

Courage comes from the same place. Dani's voice came out small, and she made it louder. Paul told young Timothy that the Spirit God gives us is a Spirit of power and love and a sound mind, and fear didn't come from Him (2 Timothy 1:7). In Acts 4 the first believers had just been threatened by the authorities, and they asked God for boldness to keep speaking. The place shook, they were all filled with the Holy Spirit, and they went out and spoke God's word boldly (Acts 4:29-31). The McDowells point to the apostles themselves, who ran and hid when Jesus was arrested and then preached in the open after they saw Him alive: "They became courageous almost overnight" (*More Than a Carpenter*, ch. 7).

And the tall one in Isaiah's eleven seconds of video? The story never says, so I won't either, though Hebrews 1:14 does tell us God sends His angels to serve the people who belong to Him.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Let's start with Isaiah, whose mom told him people see what they need to see, and that church was a story people needed. That's a real objection, and it deserves a real answer. Christianity invites the checking, and Paul's note that most of the five hundred were still alive was his way of saying go ask them. Sean McDowell writes that this generation grew up with endless information in their hands and checks what it hears, so the people answering them have to learn that "truth must be wedded to grace" (McDowell, "Introduction"). When a friend is like Isaiah, be like

Yadiel with a fist in the back of that hoodie, and hang on. Anyone who's the Isaiah in the group should bring those questions out. Isaiah still wants to know who the tall one is, and wanting to know is a good place to start.

Let's also talk about the rail. When the strap snapped, Bryce got up on his knees and looked over the rail into the dark after his grandmother's binoculars, which she used to count hawks. Yadiel told him nobody goes over that rail, not tonight and not for anything, and Bryce brushed the gravel off his jeans and stayed. Growing up clean means knowing where the rails are before the night they're needed. Paul told Timothy not to let anyone look down on him for being young, and to set an example in how he talked, how he lived, and how he kept himself pure (1 Timothy 4:12). He told the Philippians to fill their minds with whatever is true and right and pure and lovely (Philippians 4:8). Ask what we let into our heads at night with a phone in our hands.

Then think about Monday morning. For two years Dani's mother zipped that Bible into the backpack every morning, and Dani never once opened the pocket at school. On Monday, Dani took the Bible from her mother's hands and put it in the right pocket of her own coat, where she could reach it, and her mother let her. That's what it looks like when a parent's faith starts becoming a kid's own.

Try this out this week. Learn 1 John 4:2 by heart, in whatever language the family prays in. Parents can pass on the test the way Dani's mother taught it while sitting on the edge of the bed. And when a voice comes along that sounds smooth and friendly and knows a lot about us, whether it comes out of a phone or the dark below a guardrail, ask it about Jesus. Ask it if He came in the flesh, and then listen hard to what it won't say.

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